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MINI PLENARY - NATIONAL ASSEMBLY  
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VOTE NO 31 - EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR

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WEDNESDAY, 19 MAY 2026

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**PROCEEDINGS OF MINI-PLENARY SESSION - NATIONAL ASSEMBLY**  
**CHAMBER**

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Members of the mini-plenary session met at Good Hope Chamber at 16:45.

House Chairperson Mr W Horn took the Chair and requested members to observe a moment of silence for prayers or meditation.

**APPROPRIATION BILL**

Debate on Vote No 31 - Employment and Labour:

The MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR: Hon Chairperson and hon members, Deputy Ministers, acting director-general, deputy directors-general of our department, chairpersons and CEOs of our entities, our national and international social partners, my guests watching from the viewing venue, fellow South

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Africans, we table this Budget Vote of the Department of Employment and Labour at a moment of both difficulty and determination for our country. The latest Statistics SA report reminds us of a reality that South Africa's economic recovery is not translating into jobs.

While there are signs of stabilisation in the economy, including improvements in the electricity supply, moderating inflation, renewed infrastructure investment and growing investor confidence, millions of South Africans still wake up every morning without work, without income and without certainty about tomorrow. The survey highlights the continued fragility of South Africa's labour market recovery after declining from 33,2% in the third quarter of 2025 to 31,4% in the fourth quarter. The official unemployment rate rose again by 1,3 percentage points to 32,7% in the first quarter of 2026, leaving more than 8 million South Africans unemployed. The crisis confronting young people between the ages of 15 and 34 is that unemployment remains critically high at nearly 46%, underscoring the urgent need for accelerated economic growth, targeted labour market interventions and large-scale youth employment opportunities. In 1976, the youth of South Africa rose against exclusion and the denial of opportunity. As we

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honour their sacrifice, we have declared 2026 as the year of putting young South Africans to work in honour of the 1976 youth and commemoration of the youth uprising called the Jubilee.

This is a national commitment to place youth unemployment skills, workplace experience and economic participation at the centre of government, business and society. To deepen these interventions, R350 million has been committed to the government and business partnership, working with the Presidency and the National Pathway Management Network to place 130 000 young people into learning opportunities, work exposure programmes and employment interventions. In addition, R95 million has been committed to the Industrial Development Corporation, IDC, to support youth employment innovation project aimed at placing 7 000 young people into productive economic activity.

Through the Labour Activation Programme, Lab, we are repositioning and repurposing our interventions to respond more effectively to South Africa's deepening unemployment crisis and to connect unemployed South Africans to real economic opportunities. The review of the Lab strategy is now

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centred on three focus pillars aimed at improving labour market absorption, strengthening workplace experience and supporting enterprise-led job creation. The first pillar focuses on demand-led skills development aligned to needs of the labour market, working in partnership with business, public entities and training institutions.

We are ensuring that training programmes are directed towards scarce and critical skills that are required by the economy and that improve the prospects of employment absorption. The second pillar prioritises the placement of graduates, Technical and Vocational Education and Training, TVET, students and learners from higher education and training institutions into internships and work-integrated learning opportunities so that they can complete their qualifications and gain workplace exposure necessary to enter the labour market. This will include the placement of 20 000 TVET students on work-integrated learning, chartered financial analysts, chartered accountants, professional technicians and engineers, law students and health inspectors.

In addition, we will train 10 000 youth on digital skills and 10 000 for driver's licence. Through partnerships with

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employers and training institutions, we are strengthening pathways from learning into work. The third pillar focuses on intervention support for micro, small and medium enterprises through blended finance mechanisms aimed at stimulating economic activity, supporting business growth and expanding job creation.

Through these targeted interventions, the Lab is being reshaped into a more responsive instrument for employment creation, economic inclusion and sustainable livelihoods. Through targeted labour market interventions, government will recruit 200 000 unemployed people in the current financial year alone, contributing to a total of 605 000 beneficiaries over the Medium-Term Expenditure Framework, MTEF. Importantly, 70% of all opportunities will be directed towards the youth, reflecting a deliberate commitment to address the plight of unemployed young people.

The Department of Employment and Labour has been allocated R4,5 billion, representing a 10,2% increase from the previous year. Of this amount, the Department of Employment and Labour will be contributing more than R100 million to critical ICT infrastructure. Thirty-six point six billion rand over the

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MTEF has been set aside for the Labour Activation Programme. We call on all the employers to partner with us and open opportunities to place these young South Africans to either complete their studies or first-time work experience through internships. For the 2026-27 financial year, the Department of Employment and Labour has been allocated R4,5 billion as I have said, as part of building the enforcement capacity. We launched the phased implementation of Project 20 000 inspector-interns, a historic expansion of labour inspectorate aimed at strengthening the frontline presence of the Department of Employment and Labour across the country.

The first phase of the 10 000 inspector-interns commenced during 2025-26 financial year. By the end of April 2026, approximately 3 800 young interns had already entered training and deployment processes. A further 3 500 will start end of May, while 2 700 will start by end of June. These young recruits are the new boots on the ground in the fight against labour exploitation, non-compliance and workplace injustices. Project 20 000 gained further momentum - you rather listen so that you can report to your commander-in-chief, CIC. Project 20 000 gained further momentum following the announcement of

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the appointment of the 10 000 permanent labour inspectors by President Cyril Ramaphosa in the 2026 Sona.

Listen, the department will start with the recruitment of these permanent inspectors. Instead of recruiting the remaining 10 000 interns, we have set aside R5 billion for the MTEF period for this programme. We plan to modernise labour inspection systems through hybrid inspections that leverage digitisation and smart technology to improve and strengthen compliance monitoring across workplaces.

Public employment services is a frontline instrument in the fight against unemployment, where millions of work seekers face exclusion, not only because of the shortage of jobs, but because of distance, cost information barriers and fragmented systems. Access itself becomes a matter of justice. Again, the the hon member of the EFF must listen here. That is why we are strengthening employment services. South Africa is a system that is expanding online and labour centre-based services and harmonising systems with national pathway management network to ensure that unemployed South Africans are connected to jobs, training, counselling and support with greater speed, reach and fairness. Employers are now able to access the

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system directly and match with unemployed work seekers, whether they require chefs, waiters, drivers, plumbers, artisans, etc.

Employment Services of South Africa, Essa, can be accessed via [www.labour.gov.za](http://www.labour.gov.za) and click on Essa under online services tab. Through Essa, the department has built the largest government work seekers database in the country. As part of advancing more coherent and impactful public employment programme, I have approved the progression of the public employment programme review report to the director-general's clusters and Cabinet processes.

The report is informed by the need to strengthen co-ordination, planning and implementation of approximately 106 public employment programmes introduced since 1994. Upon completion of the approval processes, the report will be released for public comment as part of advancing a more coherent and impactful public employment programme framework. Three hundred and fifty million rand has been set aside for government and business partnership working with the Presidency to the National Pathways Management Network to



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place 130 000 young people into learning opportunities, work exposure, programmes and employment interventions.

In addition, R95 million has been committed to the IDC for youth employment innovation project aimed at placing 7 000 young people into productive economy. Through targeted labour market interventions, government will recruit 200 000. I am repeating that - it is part of the programme that we are doing.

One of the interventions supported through this programme has been Teacher Assistant Programme. During the 2025-26 financial year, the teacher assistant programme had recruited 158 000 young South Africans and we had budgeted or funded this programme with R4 billion. Through the network processes, the Labour Laws Amendment Bill proposes critical reforms of the Labour Relations Act, Basic Conditions of Employment Act, National Minimum Wage Act and Employment Equity Act.

These changes are aimed at strengthening worker protection, improving dispute resolutions, reducing unnecessary compliance patterns for small businesses and aligning legislation and with the Constitutional Court and labour court judgments. The

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progress is already measurable. The Labour Law Amendment Bill was approved by Cabinet, and we are expecting that this process be undertaken through the process of submitting to Parliament as we have received submissions about 216 which we are busy processing.

Since the introduction of the National Minimum Wage, it has benefited estimated 6 million workers. Following the promulgation of the Employment Equity Act and introduction of sectoral numerical targets on 1 January 2025, more than 14 000 designated employers submitted employment equity reports while over 11 000 non-designated employers applied for compliance certificate. In 2025-26 the department is targeting 3 324 employment equity inspections.

It was targeting those including director-general's reviews, reassessments and monitoring interventions. A total of only 9% of the 1 900 companies that were inspected by our department only complied - only 9%, which is 181. For the 2026-27, the Unemployment Insurance Fund has been budgeted for R41 billion. During the 2025-26 financial year, UIF True-Tel has supported 30 companies with approximately R295 million saving more than 9 300 jobs.

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We are not satisfied with this performance. We shall make sure that we put more systems in place to spend the R2,4 billion that we have budgeted for Temporary Employer-Employee Relief Scheme, Ters, this financial year. The Labour Activation Programme is allocated again a budget of 36,6 billion over the MTF. The Compensation Fund is R28 billion and R300 million is spent on a bursary programme that currently supports 4 000 students in scarce skills. The Sheltered Employment Enterprises, SEE, is the only state manufacturing entity whose core mandate is large-scale employment of persons with disability. I therefore urge all Ministers, premiers, MECs, mayors and all leaders across government to actively approach the National Treasury to seek for an exemption that will enable them to procure from supported employment enterprises.

Whether you are looking for furniture, office furniture, school furniture, hospital linen, bedding, protective clothing or institutional textiles, government must use its own procurement muscle to support this entity of our government. The National Economic Development and Labour Council, Nedlac, continues to demonstrate the strategic importance for social competing in the democracy such as ours. During 2025-26, they facilitated extensive engagements on labour law reforms.

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Productivity SA is being repositioned as a strategic delivery of productivity-driven growth, enterprise sustainability, and job retention, particularly for small, medium, and micro enterprises, SMMEs. In the current financial year, Productivity SA aims to support more than 1,300 enterprises, capacitated 2 500 workers, developed 350 productivity champions. The Commission for Conciliation, Mediation and Arbitration, CCMA, is increasingly becoming a proactive institution focused on conflict prevention.

In conclusion, in a constrained fiscal environment, this budget reflects a deliberate choice of directing resources where they can make the greatest impact in jobs. I therefore present to this House Budget Vote 31 as a statement of national purpose to build a labour market and an economy that works for all our people. I appreciate the support of the Deputy Ministers, members of the Portfolio Committee on Employment and Labour, my special advisers, the director-general and the entire Department of Employment and Labour family executives and the entire team in my office who spent sleepless nights contributing to the finalisation of this Budget Vote. It is only an abridged Budget Vote. The speech

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will be available on the website, both of Parliament and my department. Thank you very much, hon Chair.

Mr B M MANELI: Hon House Chairperson, hon Minister, hon Deputy Ministers, hon Members of the Portfolio Committee of Employment and Labor, esteemed Members of Parliament, colleagues and guests, today I rise to reflect on the budget allocation for the department and its entities with a particular focus on the strategic role of the Compensation Fund, the CF, and the Unemployment Insurance Fund, the UIF, in our nation's aspirations to drive state-led reindustrialisation through employment integration.

This Budget Vote comes at a critical juncture when South Africa faces skyrocketing unemployment rates that threaten the very fabric of our socioeconomic stability. It is therefore imperative that we harness the full potential of these two pivotal funds, not only as social protection mechanisms, but as dynamic drivers of sustainable job creation and economic transformation. This, to us as the ANC, is about the people's needs first, economic transformation first, and no retreat as we advance a better life for all agenda.

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The CF and the UIF have long served as critical pillars in supporting worker stability and productivity. Their core mandate to provide income support to workers during periods of unemployment or work-related injury is fundamental to social justice and equity. However, as we confront an evolving labour market and the urgent call for economic revival, these funds must be more than safety nets, they must become engines of empowerment, inclusivity, and growth.

This is because the entities have got capacity, particularly UIF, to create mass employment as it has proven that it has got capacity through over 158 000 job placements in the form of teaching assistants. Once more, ours is about people's needs first, economic transformation first, and no retreat. Our call as the ANC to strengthen social protection framework is not simply about preserving the status quo but about ensuring that workers can participate productively in the economy with dignity and security.

By supporting workers stability, we cultivate a workforce ready and able to contribute to reindustrialisation imperative. This is particularly significant as we aim to revive manufacturing sectors, stimulate industrial

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productivity, and create decent jobs aligned with South Africa's industrial policies.

An essential focus area in this journey is enhancing claims management efficiency within both funds. Currently, service delivery delays undermine labour market confidence and the lives of countless workers depending on timely benefits. By modernising our ICT infrastructure and streamlining benefit administration, we can significantly reduce turnaround time and improve user experience. This digital transformation will also allow us to monitor claim trends better, manage risks proactively, and foster transparency and accountability, which are key ingredients for restoring public trust and ensuring fund sustainability.

Vocational rehabilitation and return to work programmes represent another strategic value to facilitate workforce reintegration. Far too often, workers who suffer workplace injuries or who are displaced by technological and economic shifts find themselves sidelined without necessary support to regain their livelihoods. Investing in tailored rehabilitation services and creating pathways back into employment directly address this challenge. Moreover, such initiatives align with

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our broader industrial policies by ensuring an adaptive and resilient workforce ready to meet the demands of modern industries.

Prioritising labour activation programmes that target vulnerable groups such as youth, women, and people living with disabilities reflects our commitment to inclusive growth. These groups have historically borne the brunt of unemployment and marginalisation.

Dedicated interventions to upskill, activate, and integrate these populations into the workforce are fundamental to correcting structural inequities. The funds through these targeted programmes will act as catalysts, not only for the improved individual livelihoods, but for broader social cohesion and national economic recovery. Therefore, the repositioning process of these funds is a vital step in embedding the employment component within their strategies.

This is more than an administrative adjustment. It is a paradigm shift that directly links social protection with active job creation efforts. By aligning their programmed initiatives with national industrial policy, the CF and UIF



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become proactive partners in economic development, not merely reactive entities responding to labour market failures.

Supporting small enterprises, particularly through township supply development, is a primary example of this forward-looking approach. Small and medium enterprises serve as engines of job creation, innovation, and inclusive economic development. The funds' proactive investment in these enterprises ensures that employment opportunities are generated locally, especially in historically underserved areas.

This approach is tailored to building sustainable livelihoods and reducing reliance on large urban centers alone, thus facilitating more balanced regional development. Building institutional capacity, closing skills gaps among staff, and advancing fraud prevention and financial oversight are non-negotiable pillars that safeguard the funds' sustainability and public trust. In the face of increasing complexity and demand, the funds must operate with operational excellence and integrity.

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Where fraud and corruption occurred during COVID, Temporary Employee-Employer relief Scheme, TERS, law enforcement agencies, and courts built and strengthened by the ANC-led government since 1994 have been hard at work. The system works, and the system is delivering. Robust governance structures ensure that resources are utilised optimally and that the funds can respond dynamically to emerging challenges in the labour market and in the economy.

expanding employer engagement and compliance mechanisms supports the formalisation of businesses and job creation. Informal employment remains a significant barrier to labour market stability by encouraging voluntary compliance and formal integration of business into the social protection system. We can broaden the tax base, enhance labour standards, and foster inclusive economic growth.

The significance of these funds in driving state-led reindustrialisation cannot be overstated. The South African economy requires a coordinated, multifaceted strategy where employment generation is intricately linked with industrial policy. The active integration of these funds in this strategy provides a dual benefit.

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On the one hand, it ensures social protection, reaches workers efficiently. On the other, it leverages this system to stimulate job creation in priority sectors. This integrated approach effectively positions the funds as catalysts and enablers of industrial revitalisation, helping transform economic sectors in ways that create sustainable, decent employment opportunities.

The repositioning process is also symbolic of the Department of Employment and Labour's broad commitment to confront the unemployment crisis head-on. By embedding employment components within the operational frameworks of the CF and the UIF, the department asserts a direct role in tackling this challenge. This signals a decisive break from fragmented interventions towards a more strategic, coordinated, and impactful response.

In conclusion, hon House Chairpersons and colleagues, the proposed Budget Vote 31 provides a robust foundation upon which we can build a more resilient and inclusive labour market. The strategic refocusing of the CF and the UIF as dynamic vehicles to stimulate employment and economic transformation is visionary and necessary. The modernisation

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of the ICT systems, investment in vocational rehabilitation, targeted labour activation programme for vulnerable groups, support for small enterprises, and strong governance frameworks collectively represent a comprehensive package designed to tackle unemployment while fostering economic growth.

I urge, therefore, this House to support the proposed budget allocations and strategic priorities outlined today. Doing so will enable the department to fortify social protection while simultaneously driving meaningful job creation, which are key to our collective pursuit of a prosperous, inclusive South African economy. Let us seize this opportunity to champion policies that do not only protect but empower workers, invigorate our industries, and uplift communities across our nation.

As ANC, we support this budget allocation, and I thank you, House Chair.

Ms N H MBELE: Hon House Chair ...

*IsiZulu:*

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Okokuqala nje ngicela ukubingelela uNxamalala uMongameli wale nhlangano, asikwazi ukukuphikisa kodwa lokho.

*English:*

Today we stand at the crossroads, and I rise not to applaud this budget but to expose it for what it truly is, a betrayal of unemployed, a betrayal of our youth and a betrayal of the promise made to the public of South Africa.

The Department of Employment and Labour presents us with glossy figures and hollow targets, they parade number of registrations, inspections and transfers, but behind this statistics lies a grim reality.

Unemployment has risen to 32,7% in the first quarter of 2026, with youth unemployment now exceeding 60% for ages 15 to 24. This is not progress, it is a collapse.

The President stood before the nation and promised jobs. He announced that 10 000 inspectors would be employed under the Labour Activation Programme; that was a lie. The budget before us today confirms it. Not a single cent has been allocated for those inspectors.

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I'm talking about sustainable employment. Instead, we are told to accept the stipends, Expanded Public Works Programmes, EPWPs, placement and temporary relief schemes as jobs. These are not jobs, these are crumbs. They are unsustainable, short-term and designed to pacify the poor while billions are wasted.

Let us interrogate the numbers. Out of a total budget of R4,5 billion, 52% is swallowed by the current payments, salaries and operations; 45% is poured into transfers and subsidies outsourced to entities riddled with government failures; and a shameful 2,8% is left for capital expenditure, the very investment needed for modernisation, digital transformation and future capabilities.

This is not a budget for development, it is a budget for the maintenance of bureaucracy and sustainable inefficiency, it is a budget that entrenches poverty instead of breaking it.

The Labour Activation Programme, which should be a lifeline, has become a cesspool of corruption and incompetence. Billions are dispersed to contractors without due diligence, without accountability and without results.

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We have demanded a forensic investigation into the fraudulent tenders like Diphetogo Security. We have demanded transparency, yet, the department remains silent, shielding cronies, while communities starve.

Hon members, this government has perfected the art of deception. They promise jobs but delivers stipends, they promise inspectors but delivers nothing, they promise transformation but delivers corruption.

Even the President himself has proven untrustworthy, making announcements that are not backed by the budget, misleading Parliament and misleading the nation.

And let us not forget the Covid relief funds. Companies lined up to benefit from billions in relief, yet, they have not accounted for a single sustainable job creation. They have not shown how those funds were used to grow business and protect workers.

Meanwhile, informal traders, the backbone of our township and rural economies, the biggest contributors to employment, were left abandoned. They received no relief, no support, and to

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this day, they remain in dire strains, still feeling the devastating effects of Covid.

It is a tragedy that those who carry the economy on their backs are denied growth and development, while politically connected companies pocket relief funds without accountability.

We demand transparency. We demand records. We demand proof on how these billions were spent and how they will solve the unemployment crisis. Without accountability, relief becomes theft and promises become lies.

And what of the President himself? How does a head of state spend millions of rands hidden under a mattress in foreign currencies? How does he justify hiding such a vast sum while preaching austerity to the poor?

This is not leadership. It is a deception. It is a corruption at the highest level. And it is a proof that the President cannot be trusted to lead this nation out of poverty and unemployment.



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We must ask, where is the development? Where is the employment? Where is the accountability?

Instead of building sustainable industries, empowering co-operatives and investing in infrastructure, billions are wasted on programmes that collapse after a few months.

Instead of prioritizing South Africans, illegal foreign workers are absorbed into exportation companies, while our youth remain excluded.

Instead of creating dignity, this government creates dependency.

Hon members, the MKP rejects this budget. We reject the lies, we reject corruption and we reject the betrayal of people.

We demand the immediate tabling of a due diligence reports on lab contractors, a full forensic investigation into fraudulent tenders and Covid relief beneficiaries, a reallocation of funds away from bloated administration and towards sustainable job creation, real investment in digital transformation infrastructure, and youth employment, and above all,

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accountability from the President and his Cabinet for the false promises made to this nation.

This budget is not a plan for employment, it is a plan for stagnation. It is not a plan for transformation, it is a plan for deception. And it is not a plan for the people, it is a plan for the few who benefit from the corruption while millions remain unemployed.

Hon members, accountability is not negotiable.

The MKP party will not endorse fraud, will not tolerate silence and we will not allow the hopes of our people to be stolen. This is our solemn pledge.

We will fight for real jobs, real development and real dignity. We will expose every lie, every misuse of money and every betrayal of unemployment.

And to the people of South Africa, if you want a better change, if you want leadership that cares for you, that hears you, that fights for you, then put your votes where they

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matter. Vote for the MKP. Vote for dignity. Vote for the truth. Vote for the real transformation.

The time for deception is over. The time for accountability has come. And the time for people to rise is now. I thank you.

Mrs D VAN DER WALT: Chairperson and the hon members, Minister and Deputy Ministers. The Department of Employment and Labour and its entities' budget is not a story of a lack of resources, it's a story of the right money in the wrong places and the wrong priorities on policy.

The Unemployment Insurance Fund, UIF, and Compensation Fund alone generated combined annual surpluses of roughly R44 billion in the last financial year. Yet, neither entity managed to obtain a clean audit.

Any South African worker or employer will tell you just how difficult it is to claim from the UIF or Compensation Fund, or even to register and comply with the system in the first place.

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The question then becomes: Why should entities with such poor governance records, one of which recently had its commissioner dismissed, be allowed to continue accumulating massive surpluses while service delivery remains deeply inadequate?

The answer is simple. They should not.

The proof lies in how this money is being used. Both entities continue planning further investments into the failing Daybreak Foods venture, an investment that has already cost each of them roughly R400 million that will likely never be recovered.

At the same time, many of the active labour market programmes funded through these surpluses continue to produce limited employment outcomes at extremely high cost.

In sharp contrast, the institutions that actually keep our labour system functioning are under immense strain.

The Commission for Conciliation, Mediation and Arbitration, CCMA, remains underfunded and overstretched. Employers and workers alike cannot afford a labour dispute system where

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cases drag on for months, because the institution responsible for resolving disputes lacks sufficient capacity and commissioners cannot keep up with the growing caseloads.

Nedlac also plays a critical role in securing co-operation between government, labour and business. But it should be focused on practical labour market reform and social compacting that drives growth and job creation, rather than processes that produce discussions without any implementation.

So, yes, there is money in the system, but it's not being directed where it can have the greatest impact.

But, Chairperson, the most important reforms required in this country do not necessarily require more money at all. They require a fundamental rethink and labour market policy.

The department's own strategic documents speak about balancing worker protection with labour market flexibility and enterprise competitiveness. Yet, in practice, the policy direction continues moving towards a greater stringency, heavier compliance burdens and more barriers of hiring.

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South Africa absolutely needs strong protection for workers, but we also need to recognise the realities facing businesses that are expected to create employment in a stagnant economy.

Large corporates may absorb regulatory complexity, small business cannot. Every additional compliance burden becomes another reason not to hire the next worker.

We cannot continue designing labour legislation around the protection of a relatively small number of insiders, while millions of unemployed South Africans remain locked out of the economy entirely.

Take the film industry as one example. The sector survives on flexibility, project-based work and short-term contracting. Actors, crews and technical teams have traditionally operated as independent contractors because that is the nature of that industry.

The Basic Conditions of Employment Act already provides protection where working arrangements amount to full-time employment.

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But instead of recognising the realities of the sector, the department is moving towards forcing a one-size-fits-all employment model onto an industry that depends on flexibility to remain globally competitive. The cost of that stringency will not be theoretical, it will be paid in productions lost, investment diverted elsewhere and thousands of jobs disappearing in a sector that South Africa should be growing.

The point is simple. We cannot solve unemployment through spending alone while simultaneously advancing policies that make it harder, riskier and more expensive to employ people. South Africa needs a labour system that fairly balances worker protection with economic growth and job creation.

The interests of workers, businesses and the unemployed must all be considered. Above all, we must design our labour market for growth first, because without growth there will be no jobs to protect in the first place. I thank you, Chairperson.

Ms T J MOKWELE: Chairperson, greetings to the commander-in-chief, Julius Malema, commissars, fighters and fellow South Africans. Chairperson, the EFF rejects the report on Budget

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Vote 31, Employment and Labour on the Strategic Plan 2025-2030 and annual performance plan 2026-27.

South Africa's unemployment rate currently stands at about 32% with youth unemployment approaching alarming levels of ... Minister, listen ... approaching alarming levels of almost 70%. When we look at these numbers, we are looking at millions of young people sitting at home losing dignity and being stripped of their future by a system that is refusing to change.

The labour market remains deeply divided, intentionally locking out black and marginalised communities from ever accessing real economic opportunities.

Chairperson, the current budget does absolutely nothing to bridge the deep gulf between the haves and the have-nots. The report itself reveals that about 52,1% of this allocation is swallowed up entirely by compensation of employees and internal operational costs. The framework of this department is completely backward. It concentrates its vast wealth and resources on administrative maintenance and red tape instead of focusing on direct employment creation for our people.



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Chairperson, this budget speaks nothing closer to the reality on the ground, Minister. Stop with those numbers. The reality is that workers are still oppressed. Workers are still earning peanuts. Workers are still without living wages. And black workers are still not getting the same salaries as their white counterparts for doing exactly the same jobs.

Chairperson, the Unemployment Insurance Fund, UIF, and Compensation Fund are structurally broken, underperforming and riddled with allegations of corruption. South Africa needs nationalisation of key sectors of economy, not tomorrow, but right now. If we nationalise the economy of this country, we will expand and we will finally build a foundation that creates sustainable jobs, not job opportunities. Sustainable jobs with proper living wages for all workers.

The allocation for goods and services, for transfer and subsidies will never address the true need of the labour market or bring about transformation. Chairperson, the department cannot even resolve the massive fraud, corruption-facing COVID-19 Temporary Employer-Employee Relief Scheme, TERS, funding, where more than R800 million mysteriously vanished into thin air under the watch of the UIF.

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Deputy Minister Sibiya, the notorious syndicates operating within the department from Gauteng and KwaZulu-Natal remain untouched even today.

The Public Employment Services system is broken, while millions of rands are constantly thrown into outsourced services. This is a unit tasked with a critical job of matching job seekers to available employment, yet it fails our youth completely.

The report before us confirms that the department spends far more on sustaining its own heavy administrative bureaucracy than on delivering its actual mandate to our people.

Chairperson, it can never be accepted that the community of Burgersfort in Limpopo is forced to seek basic services from a small cramped rented house that is being run as a labour centre. It cannot be business as usual while the people of Klerksdorp in the North West are left completely abandoned without a functional labour centre. It can never be business as usual, while the department wasted millions constructing Taung Labor Centre only to leave it locked and empty to this very day, while a private sector company is paid month after

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month just to guard empty walls. It can never be business as usual when this house sat for hours listening to empty promises by Mr Ramaphosa claiming he would appoint labour inspectors to protect workers.

Yet, the report shows that inspection and enforcement services directorate gets miserable 15,3%. You cannot protect workers on the ground when you starve the inspectorate of resources.

Minister, we demand that you strengthen, capacitate, and permanently employ inspectors to restore the dignity of our workforce. Passing this budget - you are talking numbers, there's nothing like that, you know. Passing this budget is a direct betrayal of the thousands of unemployed graduates who have been abandoned by this state.

Passing this budget is a betrayal of the security guards, - listen, Diphetogo, a personal protective equipment, PPE, and fusion security company in the North West who have been forced to guard properties of the state for almost six months now. They haven't received any cent of their wages.

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Chairperson, the EFF calls upon this House to support its insourcing ... [Inaudible.] ... to protect workers and crush corruption embedded within government entities. We call upon South Africans, Chairperson, who love this country to stand up, go out, register, and vote the EFF on the 4th of November 2026 to take back dignity and render services to our people.

Amandla! [Power!]

Mr S L NGCOBO: Hon House Chair, it is unfortunate that this Budget Vote takes place in the wake of the recently released unemployment statistics which revealed a 1,3% increase in the unemployment.

Behind these figures are not merely 300 000 jobs lost but families deprived of income and secondary economies stripped of such needed spending power. This crisis is further compounded by the rising cost of living, particularly the escalating cost of electricity and transport which continue to place immense pressure on the already struggling households.

One of the core mandates of the department is to promote employment and effectively regulate South African labour

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market. However, as the IFP has consistently maintained, this objective cannot be fully realised without the strict enforcement of the 80-20 employment target whereby companies may be required to employ a minimum of 80% South Africans.

Furthermore, then the remaining 20% that would be allocated to the non-South Africans should be limited strictly to individuals possessing critical and scarce skills.

The IFP believes that such measures will not only accelerate job creation for South Africans but will also ensure that the department meaningfully contributes towards achieving the objectives of the Medium-Term Development Plan, particularly the goal of reducing unemployment and expanding the economic participation.

The fiscal constraints facing government are neither new nor unexpected and therefore cannot continuously be relied upon as a justification for inefficiency. While the IFP recognises the difficult financial environment under which the department operates, this reality necessitates a department that is agile, innovative and responsive to the challenges confronting the people of South Africa. The effective use of limited

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resources has become more important than ever in ensuring that service delivery and employment objectives are achieved.

Furthermore, this issue of illegal immigration is not only a security concern but also an economic one, particularly in the context of the rising unemployment and growing pressure on public resources.

The recent increase in public marches and demonstrations against illegal migration must be taken seriously by the department as they reflect the frustration and anxieties of many South Africans who feel excluded from the economic opportunities.

It is therefore concerning that the inspection and enforcement services branch receives the smallest share of the department's budget despite the critical role it plays in enforcing labour laws, such as compliance and addressing the exploitation of undocumented labour.

Strengthening this unit is essential if the department is to effectively regulate the labour market and resource public confidence in the system. The IFP welcomes the mitigation of

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this concern through filling funded inspector vacancies and the reprioritisation of resources, risk-based inspections, and improved operational planning.

The Public Employment Services remains an important and necessary intervention by the department, particularly within constrained economic environment characterised by persistent structural unemployment, weak labour absorption, and limited opportunities for job seekers.

In such conditions, the state has a critical role to play in connecting unemployed South Africans with available opportunities, supporting skills development, and facilitating pathways into the labour market. The IFP, however, supports this budget.

Thank you very much.

Ms J A BASSON: Hon House Chairperson, Minister and Deputy Minister, from a political perspective, this report is far too safe. It critiques insufficiency and weak implementation but avoids confronting the deeper crisis of leadership failure and the real consequences that fail every South African.

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*Afrikaans:*

As die PA ondersteun ons hierdie begroting maar hierdie verslag praat 'n taal van systems, frameworks en compliance [stelsels, raamwerke en nakoming] maar sê bittermin van die mense wat elke dag met die pyn van werkloosheid moet saamleef.

Agter elke unemployment statistic [statistiek oor werkloosheid] is daar 'n mens, 'n jong graduate [gegradueerde] wat by die huis sit sonder 'n kans, 'n ma wat met informal [informele] werk moet probeer oorleef, 'n township entrepreneur [swart woonbuurt entrepreneur] wat sonder toegang tot fondse of markte moet survive [oorleef], 'n werker wat exploitation [uitbuiting] aanvaar omdat daar geen alternatief is nie.

Jong mense vra nie framework [raamwerk] dokumente nie. Hulle vra vir werk, hulle vra vir opportunity [geleentheid], hulle vra vir dignity [waardigheid.] Ons spandeer miljoen op regulation [regulasie], governance [bestuur] en administration [administrasie] maar te min op job creation [werkskepping], labour absorption [arbeidsopname] and economic expansion [en ekonomiese uitbreiding.] Ons meet sukses aan reports [verslae] wat ingedien word, nie aan jobs [werk] wat geskep moet word



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nie. Suid-Afrikaners kan nie governing models  
[bestuursmodelle] eet nie. Ons kan nie compliance [nakoming]  
oorleef nie.

Elke jong mens kan nie 'n toekoms bou op 'n strategiese plan  
wat nooit 'n werk word nie. Die ware toets van hierdie  
begroting is eenvoudig. Kan gewone mense werk kry? Kan  
families oorleef? Kan mense met dignity [waardigheid] leef?

Hierdie debat gaan nie oor systems [stelsels] nie. Dit gaan  
oor mense - ons mense. Ons moet ophou vra of programme bestaan  
en meer begin vra of dit werk. Minder paperwork [papierwerk],  
meer realiteit.

Van die mense van die Kaapse Vlakte [Cape Flats] tot die  
strate van Mpumalanga verdien werk, verdien wette in labour  
[arbeid] en employment [indiensneming] wat vir almal werk. Vir  
te lank was die bruin mens in die verlede te lig en te donker  
in die hede, die kind van die township [swart woonbuurt] te  
ongeskool vir bestuursposte [management positions.], die  
huidige blanke kind blameer vir apartheid.

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Hierdie begroting is net mooi woorde op papier en die ...  
realiteit wat ek as 'n Member of Parliament [parlements lid],  
vergadering na vergadering, oversight na oversight [toesig na  
toesig] in hierdie kommitee beleef.

*English:*

It's time we admit our shortcomings. It's time we take hands  
with every race in this country to implement and write laws  
that achieve work for every race in this country. Our Deputy  
Minister had a meeting with the Chinese factories in  
Newcastle. Millions of rand for top-notch brand clothing;  
textile industry - work stolen from our own communities. To  
this day, there is no report, no update and no labour and  
employment implementers. These factories are still operating,  
still hiring illegal people and still being run as sweatshops.

*Afrikaans:*

Ek kan nie hier sit en sê hierdie debat wat voor my staan die  
waarheid is nie.

*English:*

We need to do better and better starts with each and every one  
of us in this room. I thank you.

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Mr W M THRING: Hon House Chair, let me firstly appreciate hon Beesley for allowing me to swap places with him.

Hon House Chair, as the ACDP, we are acutely aware that South Africa's unemployment crisis remains one of the greatest threats to our economy, social stability and national dignity. Millions of South Africans, especially young people, remain excluded from meaningful economic participation.

This Budget Vote must therefore be measured by one question: Will it help sustainable jobs and restore hope to our people? While the ACDP recognises the importance of protecting workers' rights, promoting decent work and ensuring safe workplaces, labour policy must also support economic growth, investment and enterprise development.

This R4,5 billion budget faces serious resistance from governance failures in the department. Persistent delays and inefficiencies at the Unemployment Insurance Fund and Compensation Fund leave vulnerable workers without timely relief, while weak consequence management and recurring information and communications technology, ICT, failures continue to frustrate both workers and employers.

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The portfolio committee has rightfully highlighted ongoing weaknesses in administration, audit outcomes, enforcement capacity and oversight across key entities, including the UIF, Compensation Fund, Commission for Conciliation, Mediation and Arbitration, CCMA, and National Economic Development and Labour Council, Nedlac. These failures damage trust and discourage compliance.

The ACDP understands that small and medium enterprises remain the greatest potential source of job creation, yet many are suffocated by rising costs, excessive compliance burdens, unreliable infrastructure and regulatory uncertainty. Simultaneously, there remains a serious mismatch between available skills and labour market demand. Too many young people leave the education system without the practical and technical skills needed in sectors such as manufacturing, agriculture, infrastructure, technology and energy.

As kingdom builders, the ACDP proposes three key priorities. Firstly, expand vocational training, apprenticeships, artisan development and labour activation programmes aligned to the private sector demand. Secondly, unnecessary regulatory burdens on small businesses must be reduced while maintaining

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fair labour protections that encourage job creation. Thirdly, urgent reforms are needed at the UIF and Compensation Fund to improve governance, strengthen ICT systems, eliminate corruption and ensure efficient service delivery.

Employment is more than an income. It restores dignity, strengthens families and builds safer communities. This budget must translate into job opportunities and economic renewal. I thank you.

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR (Ms J Nemadzinga-Tshabalala): Chairperson of the portfolio committee, hon Minister, members of the portfolio committee, the hon Minister of Employment and Labour, Ms Nomakhosazana Meth, the Deputy Minister of Employment and Labour, Mr Ntuthuko Sibiya, and of course, the officials in the department led by the Auditor-General and also the members of the public, we greet you all. Now, this year, this debate takes place during a very symbolic period in the life of our nation.

On 8 May, we celebrated the 30th anniversary of the adoption of the democratic Constitution of the Republic of South Africa. In the month of August, we'll be commemorating the

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70th anniversary of the historic march to the Union Building by women of our country, and women belonging necessarily to the struggle. Of course, we say:

*IsiZulu:*

Wathint'abafazi, wathint'imbokodo! [You strike a woman, you strike a rock]

*English:*

We will also commemorate this year, the 50 years since the June 1976 uprising. We say to the ANC Youth League: Fight, produce and learn. In this student uprising, when young people sacrificed their lives, demanding a future that will liberate them through the quality education. Now, what's important is that this year, we commemorate the Women's Month under the theme: Bill of Rights 30, making the human dignity real.

The Bill of Rights that was born out of the Freedom Charter that was adopted 71 years ago, and this year again, it boldly declared this courage that we had, that conviction that spoke about there shall be work and security for all. The declaration was not simply a political statement, it was an economic compromise, if not promise, a promise that freedom

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would ultimately be measured by dignity, equality and opportunity.

These anniversaries compel us not to only celebrate the history, but also to confront honestly the present reality of our country. From the earliest days of the democratic state, the ANC understood that employment is not just an economic matter, but it is a social justice and is imperative. That is a government that continues to work.

It is within this context that this budget advances that mission through the strategic pillars and this was brought by the ANC. The protection of workers through enforcement and compliance, the creation of inclusive employment opportunities, the building of a productive economy capable of completing globally, that is the system that continues to work. We have an entity called the Supported Employment Enterprises that stands as one of the most powerful instruments of economic inclusion.

This portfolio is mandated to provide meaningful employment for persons with disabilities that reflects the constitutional values of equality and human dignity. We must also acknowledge

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its challenges that it finds itself, primarily because it's unable to attract the necessary jobs that needs to have for it to continue the work that it does.

In the 13 factories that it has throughout the country, it has seen that the employment has went down, primarily because of the issue of not attracting the necessary jobs. That's why in the state of the nation address, Sona, debate of this year, our President has urged all the departments to make sure that it does procure from this entity to ensure that we reach ultimately the 7% of employment of persons with disability come 2030. So, we declare today, as well as the department, that we need the departments to procure from this entity.

While we add it as well, we want to also report here that we have met with the Premier of Mpumalanga, who also has expressed in all the factories that we have in the country, Mpumalanga doesn't have. We have made sure that there is a process that we are involving ourselves with the premier and his government, should have the factory this year. Now, in all the challenges that the SEE has, the issues of its legality, we are saying we will be clarifying that through our legislation framework that we will do to strengthen the



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oversight accountability and make sure the system has its credibility.

We have an entity called Productivity SA that is also recognised as Africa Kaizen Centre of Excellence, positions South Africa as a continental leader in the productive improvement. However, hon members, expanding the impact requires the sustained funding, especially skills and stronger partnerships within municipalities, industry and international institution. I want to say to the members that came and debated and you were speaking about the issue of the Temporary Employer-Employee Relief Scheme, TERS, funding and the COVID-19, the department through its the Special Investigating Unit, SIU, it is charging people, people are getting arrested. So, I don't know which country we're living in and what you're not observing.

In labour centers there has been arrests that are happening and that is a reality. The wheel and the tide is turning and this is a government and state that continues to work. The inspection services, we also want to commend it under our Deputy Minister, Sibiyi, that is always on the ground, even tomorrow they will be doing inspections. When you say, there

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is an hon member that said the issue of the Chinese from private equity, PE, companies that were arrested, you must start by commending the work of the department led by that Deputy Minister. So, you should be an honest person when you debate. She says that there's no report to date. I can tell you that hon Sibiya with its inspectorate, they met with the Chinese embassy.

Almost 31 companies today, will co-operate. They are working with the Inspection and Enforcement Services, IES, inspectorate to make sure there's issues of labour that is recognised, the issues of minimum wage, also the issues of making sure that they register them under the Unemployment Insurance Fund, UIF, and Compensation Fund, CF. So, you must follow properly, don't debate for the sake of debating. You must bring facts here.

Now, we want to recognise their work and the President announced that we will have 10 000 this year in Sona in terms of the inspectorate. The process is also unfolding and we want to commend the department under its deputy director-general, DDG, to continue with the work. The Minister has spoken about the project 20 000.

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We want to also say to you we have an entity called the Commission for Conciliation, Mediation and Arbitration, CCMA, that has produced and that has been very excellent, and none of the members are speaking about, that has ensured labour rights of people, that is happening today. This year they are celebrating their 30 years of excellence and that are resolving millions of labour disputes, fairly promoting labour peace and accessible to justice since 1994. Now, the EFF member makes noise. However, this is the CCMA and a department that assists even your labour desk whenever there's issues.

Now, let me respond to you. When you speak about Klerksdorp, right now there are trucks that are going around servicing persons of Klerksdorp. There are many centres that are there. So, the only thing you know is corrupt activities. You're not telling us about your president that is convicted and all of that. You are mumbling and trying to be relevant, you speaking about our President here ... [Interjections.] ... our President did not steal the money! ... [Inaudible.] ... am ready!

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Ms T J MOKWELE: ... on a point of order, Chair. You are speaking about our president here. Our president did not steal the money!

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Deputy Minister, would you take your sit. Hon member, what is your point of order?

Ms T J MOKWELE: Sit down, Deputy Minister. The Deputy Minister must not come here and speak about the commander-in-chief.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon member, can you please raise a point of order?

Ms T J MOKWELE: Her President, ... her President, was found with money, almost billions of ... [Inaudible.] ... in couches ...

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): ... hon member, please take your sit.

Ms T J MOKWELE: ... [Interjections.] ... the EFF is ...  
[Interjections.] ... it's on appeal. That sentence is on  
appeal ... [Interjections.] ...

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The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): ... hon members on both sides of the House, please, calm down. Order! Hon Minister! Hon member of the EFF ... hon member of the EFF ... hon members ... Hon Minister! Please, switch off the microphones. I will switch off the microphones because the members ... hon Minister, I don't think that is good behaviour. Hon member of the EFF, do you mind to leave the House? Can you, please ... there was no point of order ... no, no ... hon member! ... [Interjections.] ...

Ms T J MOKWELE: ... to leave conditionally ...

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): ... hon member ... according to the rules ... it doesn't have to ask, will you please stand up and apologise to the House for your unruly behaviour. There is no point of order, I'm not going to allow any more points of order on the same thing. I've made a ruling, an apology will be accepted.

Ms T J MOKWELE: Chair ... but for the purpose of me being here and listening to the speakers that are not being truthful, I will apologise. I want to be here and listen to the speakers that are not truthful.

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The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Thank you. Thank you very much. Hon deputy ... do you have a point of order on the same issue? If it's on the same issue, that's not a point of order.

Ms P MARAIS: No, no, no, Chairperson.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Point of order, please.

Ms P MARAIS: She must withdraw saying that my president is a criminal. She must withdraw it, because Cyril Ramaphosa is a criminal.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon member ...

Ms P MARAIS: Not my commander-in-chief, CIC, is a criminal. She must withdraw it first.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): I will listen to the Hansard and make a ruling on the next sitting. Thank you. Hon Deputy Minister, please, continue.

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR (Ms J Nemadzinga-Tshabalala): Thank you so much, House Chair. I was never going

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to withdraw. I didn't mention the name of a member of the House. They must get it clear. I know the Rules of the House. They must read. Hon members, as I'm about to also wrap up, it is important for all of us ... [Interjections.] ...

Ms T J MOKWELE: On a point of order, Chair. Sorry.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Deputy Minister, please, take your chair.

Ms T J MOKWELE: Thank you very much. Yes, I agree that the Deputy Minister did not mention the name, but she did mention the president of the EFF, and we only have one member.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon member, I already ruled on that. There's already a ruling. There's no further points of order on that same issue. Thank you.

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR (Ms J Nemadzinga-Tshabalala): Thank you so much for extending my stay here with frivolous points of order. Let me continue. Hon members, all of us must remember, and I quote: "Flower of peace cannot be sustained by poverty and by want." Our democracy continue to

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wrestle with the triple challenges of poverty, unemployment and inequality. The structural challenges are now compounded by this rising crime, economics, uncertainty and persistent joblessness that weighs heavily on our communities across the country.

We must acknowledge the frustration of fellow South Africans that remain particularly young people, that graduate who pass qualifications and ambitions and hope, yet find themselves languishing without employment opportunities. Their frustration is real, it's legitimate and it's understandable. As leaders entrusted with public responsibility, we must respond not with divisiveness of not defending, but with also all the humanity and honesty and decisive action and only by pulling together as South Africans, including political parties, to make sure we deal with the issue of unemployment.

I want to quote the revolutionary Karl Marx that once said, and I quote: "The point is not only to understand the suffering of people, but to change the material conditions that produce it."



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Our President, Nelson Mandela in 1999, during the May Day rally in Kimberley, when he said, I quote: "No longer do we have a government that sees farm workers as deserving of the same rights as others." This system in the ANC government is the one that has brought the rights. President Mandela says: "No longer will the use of child labour be allowed." This is the department that ensures that it has protected those rights, a system that continues to work under the ANC.

Now, all of us as the Department of Employment and Labour, we are honestly confronting these challenges, united in purpose and inspired by the vision of the Freedom Charter that includes that, South Africans belong to all who live in it, black and white. Let us ensure that we hold together and not also listen to these ones that have nothing to offer but telling us about their president's vote for this MK Party. They have nothing to offer. The only thing is that it remains that party that doesn't have democracy. A party of ...

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): ... hon Deputy Minister, your time has expired. Hon Deputy Minister, your time has expired ...

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The DEPUTY MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR (Ms J Nemadzinga-Tshabalala): ... leadership every day and we can't ...

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): ... .. hon Deputy Minister, your time has expired ...

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR (Ms J Nemadzinga-Tshabalala): ... it is not, I've nine seconds. It is here. I'm watching the clock ... [Interjections.] ...

An HON MEMBER: ... people are voting the MK Party on 04 November ... [Interjections.] ...

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR (Ms J Nemadzinga-Tshabalala): ... no! But the clock is not stopping! It is not stopping! We want to thank you and we support this Budget Vote.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Deputy Minister! ... Hon members, ... hon members, can you please quiet down. Hon members, can you please quiet down. I want to remind all members, including the Minister and the Deputy Minister to adhere to the Rules of this House. I will, therefore, also

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want to remind you that it's against the rules to take a photo or any video during the plenary. The next speaker is hon Beesley.

Mr A D BEESLEY: Hon Chairperson, ... yet the Minister of no labour and no employment had any honour she would have resigned long time ago. But it is clear that she does not. As such ActionSA has repeatedly called on the President to fire the Minister.

A year ago, we wrote to the President formerly requesting her removal. Yesterday we wrote gain. The message has not changed. The Minister remains in office, and South Africans continue to shared hundreds and thousands of jobs. ActionSA makes this call for the Minister to be fired on behalf of the 345 000 of the people who lost their jobs in the first quarter of this year. On behalf of the 30 000 South Africans who lot their job every week and the 6 000 who lose their jobs every ingle day.

ActionSA makes this call for the Minister to be fired on behalf of the 12 million South Africans are either unemployed or so discouraged that they have given up looking for work all together. ActionSA makes this call for the Minister to be

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fired on behalf of the 60% of young people aged between 15 and 24 years who are unemployed. ActionSA makes this call for the Minister to be fired on behalf of the 11% of the graduates who cannot find employment in the country they were educated to serve. With the expanded unemployment rate now at a record of 43,7%, it is clear that the Minister, her Deputies and her Government of National Unity, GNU, as a whole have no coherent plan to address these crises.

Unemployment is not merely an economic statistic; it is a human tragedy. Behind these numbers are 12 and million individuals whose dreams, agencies, hope and often sense of purpose have been eroded. The consequences are severe and far-reaching while they are often have been described as psychological murder. Yet for the Minister, and her Deputies and the GNU Cabinet, they appear to be no consequences at all. They continue to earn generous salaries, receive luxurious packs and live a life of comfort while 12 million South Africans are left in a state of despair.

Hon Chairperson, behind this blood bath in the labour market there are also grave concerns with the department itself.

Chief among them is the rampant corruption and mismanagement

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within the Compensation Fund and the Unemployment Insurance Fund, UIF. These funds exist to protect and support working South Africans at their most vulnerable moments. Instead, they have been hollowed out and treated as slush funds for fraud, maladministration and capture. In the process the dignity of workers is being stripped away by those entrusted to safeguard it.

Hon Chairperson, the purpose of this Vote is to reduce unemployment, poverty and inequality by advancing the objectives of decent work for all. The employment creation and enterprise development, the setting and enforcement of labour standards, the protection of workers rights, the facilitation of equal opportunities and social dialogue and the provision of social protection.

However, based on past performance and the continued inability of the current leadership of this department and the GNU to address the job crises; it is clear that these objectives will not be achieved, instead unemployment, poverty and inequality will continue to rise.

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Chairperson, on behalf of the 12 million South Africans who are being economically and psychologically murdered every day ActionSA rejects this budget. Once again, we make a call for the Minister of no labour and no employment to be fired. I thank you.

Mrs N L HLAZO-WEBSTER: Hon Chairperson, I have been listening to the political back and forth that has been taking place in defence of party leaders in this House today. I really just want us as this House to perhaps for a moment think about a South African sitting at home that is actually watching these proceedings that is unemployed, that is discouraged that is wondering whether there is any one in this Chamber that actually truly understands the wait of what they are carrying.

For while we as political parties can sit here insults, there are 12 million South Africans that remain without work or who have given up hope of finding work all together.

So, today we debate Budget Vote No 31 against a backdrop of a deepening unemployment crises that has become normalised in South Africa.

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The latest Quarterly Labour Force Survey paints a devastating picture. South Africa's expanded unemployment rate now stands at 43,7% and that means that we have 12 million South Africans that are without work that are locked out of opportunities. A generation that is locked out of opportunity. This has happened under the Government of National Unity, GNU. Under the GNU South Africans are now seeing fewer jobs than under previous administration and that points to a lack of policy cohesion, a lack of urgency, and a lack of administrative capability. This Department of Employment and Labour continues to spend billions on intervention and support programmes while the labour market actually continues to deteriorate.

Unemployment is no longer treated as a national emergency in this country it has become normalised. Having said this, there is the issue of unemployment and of getting work and access to work, but economic justice is not only about access to work is also about fairness, dignity and equality once South Africans are in the workplace itself.

That is why as Bosa we are welcoming the growing national support for our Fair Pay Bill with final 10 days of the public participation now underway. We have nearly 3 000 submissions

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that we have received in support of the Bill over the past 20 days and that includes backing from civil society from organisations in the labour sector formations such as Cosatu and Motor Industry Staff Association, Misa. The Bill introduces three very simple but very transformative reforms that is the ending of salary history discrimination, the requiring of salary transparency and job advertisements and strengthening equal pay for equal work. So, it is about fairness, dignity and building a labour market that is based on merit rather than secrecy and exploitation.

We therefore urge members of this portfolio committee to consider this Bill favourably and I want to directly challenge the DA specifically the hon Michael Bagrain to review the stance on this Bill. I want to ask them why would any party oppose pay transparency? Why would anyone defend vague and opaque hiring practices that continue to ... Thank you. [Time expired.]

Mr V ZUNGULA: Hon Chairperson, I am here. Can I proceed?

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Yes, please.



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Mr V ZUNGULA: Hon Minister, the crises of unemployment in our country is a ticking timebomb. With these crises, the department must be intentional about fighting unemployment. The reality is that there are jobs in South Africa, however, the private sector prefers to employ foreign nationals in order to underpay and exploit them.

The fact that there are sectors in our country in which the majority of the workforce is the foreigners is an indictment in this department. For it is the failure of this department that allows capital to exploit the foreign workers and sideline South Africans and thus create conflict in the communities.

Hon Minister, people must not be misled. The issue of foreign workers being employed ahead of South Africans will need more than labour inspectors. We have done inspections before and we know this. The competency to deal with undocumented foreign workers lies with immigration officers. You can employ over the 10 000 labour inspectors, but if the immigration officers remain only 832 in our country, the problem will not be solved.

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You need to engage the Minister of Home Affairs. So, an increase in labour inspectors is also coupled with an increase in immigration officers. If your commitment to deal with the capital that is exploiting foreign workers is genuine.

Equally, the fines for companies employing foreign workers without a valid documentation is not a deterrent hence companies continue employing illegal foreigners as they know that a fine is just slap on the wrist.

The problem with this department is the weak enforcement of laws and the inability of the department to aggressively advance the interests of South Africans. The department must also drive policy changes in our economy to be more manufacturing-driven in order to create jobs.

The protection of some sectors of the economy for citizens and the local production of basic goods will definitely create jobs.

The department must also drive the government spending to be more on Small, Medium and Micro Enterprises, SMMEs, in order to create jobs and reduce the unemployment levels in our

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country. We expect the department to drive such economic policy changes that are pro-job creation, ensuring the economy is transformed for the benefit of the people.

Lastly, given the failures of this department, we call upon all South Africans for one jobs and the transformed economy to register and vote for the ATM an organisation that has proven, it cares for South Africans, and it has a plan to improve their lives.

We want to invite all South Africans this weekend in Buffalo City Municipality Stadium at Gomo Sports Field where a manifesto to improve the lives of South Africans will be tabled. We want to commit to you South Africans that ATM has always stood by your side. Thank you. [Time expired.]

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): The hon member of the ANC on the right-hand side. I do not know your name. Please, if you want to speak, ask your party to put you on the speakers list.

The next speaker is the Deputy Minister of Social Development, the hon Hendricks.

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The DEPUTY MINISTER OF SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT: Hon Chairperson, Al Jama-ah supports this budget and the hard work of the department to reduce unemployment has not gone unnoticed. Al Jama-ah met the leadership of the African, Asian and Arab diaspora over the past three months. These diasporas have no quarrels to follow the laws of South Africa on immigration and to apply for refugee status, residency and citizenship and accept the outcome of the applications and seek elsewhere for safety and greener pastures.

They understand that South Africans feel that they are taking their jobs. Every diaspora leader I met with who are prepared to create jobs especially those in business and spaza shops level and shopping malls, in a corporate world and in manufacturing industries. So, they are computing how many jobs they have already created for local South Africans, and they want to double it as a start.

They are prepared to work with government to create half a million jobs and agree on the timetable.

Al Jama-ah supports this budget and ask that the Minister work with his parliamentary constituency to take up the offer of

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the diasporas. In the meantime, the research is in place, and a state of readiness is on the radar that will double the jobs.

Hon Chairperson, Tanzania led the liberation committee, and African countries got their freedom one-by-one. They only closed down the secretariat when South Africa got its freedom in 1994. What is not well-known is that Tanzania quietly paid the annual fees of South African liberation formations. Asking South Africans to leave is a setback to the Africa Continental Free Trade Area. This trade will grow South Africa's gross domestic product, GDP, to over 10% and create millions of jobs.

This is now in danger of being lost. The Africa Continental Free Trade Area will also make South Africa a more prosperous country. We will be looking at a five trillion GDP in Africa. It is seven years now, and on the radar is seven years of prosperity.

Let me incentivise political parties of the Seventh Parliament and those knocking on the doors. You can say the votes of the diaspora South African citizens have many people in the

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diaspora have South African citizenships. You are shooting yourself in the foot by trying to marginalise them. Al Jama-ah supports this Budget. Thank you very much.

*Afrikaans:*

Mnr W W WESSELS: Agb Voorsitter, die Minister het begin deur om te verwys na die krisis wat werkloosheid is en sy is heeltemal reg. Terwyl dit 'n krisis is en niemand dit kan ontken nie aangesien amper die helfte van ons bevolking werkloos is en baie nie meer werk soek nie want hulle is so moedeloos vir werksoek, is dit 'n krisis.

Die departement is in 'n paradoksale dilemma. Ek sê so omdat die departement aan die eenkant 'n werkskeppingsmandaat het en aan die anderkant 'n arbeidsmandaat het wat juis eintlik baie keer daartoe lei dat werkseleenthede eintlik belemmer word en die privaatsektor nie werk kan skep nie weens oorregulering en sekere wetgewing en beleid wat bestaan en wat onder die departement val. Hier moet 'n balans wees.

*English:*

Many of us in this House will disagree about labour legislation and regulations being barriers to job creation.

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But it serves no purpose for the department to talk about workers' rights, whilst this department entities are dysfunctional, entities that are in real terms supposed to serve and assist workers.

The Compensation Fund is one of these. Whilst this fund yields a surplus of billions, it is plagued by dismal operational performance. The fund's failures leave injured workers waiting for compensation for years. This is a failure of workers' rights.

The Unemployment Insurance Fund is another of these failed entities. This fund is supposed to be a safety net for the unemployed, but it is mismanaged and much needed payouts are delayed. Women who are dependent on the Unemployment Insurance Fund, UIF, during unpaid maternity leave are failed when these claims take more than four months to process and pay out. Allowing these backlogs and failures to process claims are failing the department's mandate of protecting human dignity and social security.

Whilst the department's actions, as alluded to by the Deputy Minister in terms of consequences for those who have

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transgressed with the Temporary Employer/Employee Relief Scheme, TERS, funding, are welcomed, the problem of a lack of consequence management and accountability of these external entities remain dim.

Fourty five percent of this budget is transferred to these entities. So, they must be better internal controls. And it cannot be that the leadership of these entities year in and year out fail. And it cannot be that there is a lack of accountability and that this just continues year in and year out. I think you Chairperson.

Mr M BAGRAIM: Madam Chair, the Department of Employment and Labour has two functions only. They are well described by the changed name. It has not, however, done a good job in meeting either of them. Firstly, the emphasis is on employment. As we know, since the name change occurred, the creation of employment has fallen off a cliff.

The department has failed in its mission. Where it should be implementing pro-growth employment strategies, it is falling short. Some Government of National Unity, GNU, green shoots are emerging, but we must go further and faster.



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Setting small businesses free from the stringent wage deals agreed by big business and big unions at the Bargaining Council is key to the growth of our economy. There's no reason why this exemption should be limited to two years. If, as the National Development Plan provides, Small and Medium Enterprises, SMEs, are supposed to provide 90% of the new jobs by 2030.

When it comes to labour, the department is supposed to have some sort of oversight and ensure employed labour in South Africa is protected in accordance with the rights given to our labour force under both our Constitution and the various labour statutes, as it should do.

When it comes to protecting the rights and interests of South African workers, the department has fallen well short. Our labour force depends on the UIF to step in when times are difficult. Injured workers are supposed to be compensated by the Compensation Fund. Instead, they must wait in queues or face unreliable online systems only to be deprived of their rightful compensation. This is not a resources issue. Both entities have huge surpluses sitting at the stands for

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the Public Investment Corporation, PIC. It's a government issue.

No wonder then that the former UIF commissioner was dismissed in February without a word in public from the Minister. The Minister is always keen to introduce more and more requirements on employers, making hiring more expensive and disrupting longstanding industries like the film production sector with misguided regulations.

When it comes to the Labour Inspectorate, the department cannot ensure that the South African workers are being properly treated. Bearing in mind that the department has missed the mark at two and only two functions it has, we need to then look at the budget. We know and the public knows that budgeting should be a simple thought process. Firstly, we need to know what the department requires and whether it can deliver on these requirements. And secondly, what sort of resources have we able to fund the budget? But when a department has lost the thread on both its functions, this becomes a difficult process indeed.

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We are all aware that there are certain entities within the failing department which despite all odds still continue to deliver. We are aware that the Commission for Conciliation, Mediation and Arbitration, CCMA, and National Economic Development and Labour Council, NEDLAC, are both world class and both are suffering because of budget cuts. My heart goes out to the directors of both functional entities who are watching their world-class institutions being sacrificed at the altar of incompetence, experience and all other entities within the department.

Likewise, I sympathize, unlike others present in this House, with the millions who are waiting in job queues and deserve an apology from the Minister insistent on archaic labour regulations which lead to job destruction at their expense.

The second apology ought to be made by the entities within the department who have no understanding of service delivery at all. The DA calls for a complete overhaul and a restructure of these failing entities and for the enhancement of the budget for those that are actually delivering. Thank you, Madam Chair.

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The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C LABUSCHAGNE): Hon members, earlier on, a point of order was raised by hon Mokwele alleging that the hon Deputy Minister had referred to the President of the EFF as a criminal. The hon Minister only made reference to the President who has been convicted. I want to caution all members to stick to the subject matter of this budget vote.

Mr M NONTSELE: Hon Chairperson, hon Minister, hon Deputy Ministers, hon Chairperson of the portfolio committee and hon members, esteemed Members of Parliament, colleagues and guests, today I rise in support of the Budget Vote 31 on behalf of the African National Congress, a Budget Vote that epitomises our collective commitment as ANC to confront and overcome the scourge of unemployment that continues to afflict our beloved country. This budget, hon Van der Walt, is not merely an allocation of resources but a decisive strategic intervention on our mission to reshape the labour market, empower workers and promote inclusive economic growth.

At the heart of this effort lie two pivotal institutions, the Commission for Consolidation, Mediation and Arbitration, CCMA, and the National Economic Development and Labour Council, Nedlac. These entities are cornerstones in the ANC's vision

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for a stable and just labour market, a vision informed by the values of our freedom struggle and the practical needs of economic transformation.

Hon House Chair, the CCMA's significance cannot be overstated. It serves as the frontline labour relations, providing an impartial and accessible forum for dispute resolution between employers and employees. Its role extends beyond dispute resolution. It fosters industrial peace, a prerequisite for economic productivity and job retention. The allocation in this budget aimed at enhancing CCMA's digital transformation as a milestone, hon Bagraim. By leveraging modern technology, the CCMA will increase its efficiency, reduce the time taken to resolve labour disputes and extend accessibility to all workers, especially those in vulnerable and underserviced communities.

Digitalisation paves the way for a responsive, transparent and user-friendly service that is critical to maintaining the labour market stability in an era defined by rapid economic and technological change. It is also important that we need also to situate the South African conditions in a proper context, particularly when we talk about unemployment. We need

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to consider, hon members, that South Africa is not an island on its own. It exists within a global environment. The tariff wars, the situation in the Middle East, you need to factor all those. In notwithstanding that, you need to factor also the more than 350 years of liberation struggle that we must contend with, hence the backlogs and the current unemployment.

Hon House Chair, the CCMA also plays a proactive role in shaping labour landscape through collective bargaining and social justice initiatives. These interventions are essential in addressing inequality and vulnerability in our workplaces, ensuring that the labour market becomes a tool for social transformation aligned with our policy imperative as the African National Congress aimed towards fairness and dignity for all workers as reflected in our January 8 Statement. Complementing this is the indispensable role of Nedlac, the tripartite platform where government, labour, business and community converge to negotiate and build consensus on socioeconomic policies.

Nedlac embodies the spirit of social partnership, a mechanism through which diverse interests find common ground and shared purpose. This is particularly important in our country where

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historical divisions, which I've spoken about earlier on, and socioeconomic disparities necessitate dialogue that is both inclusive and robust. As we have stated in our January 8 Statement, presented by our President, Comrade Matamela Cyril Ramaphosa, and it reads:

The ANC committed to an inclusive and people-led national dialogue that reflects the hopes, frustrations and aspirations of South African people. The national dialogue should produce a widely inclusive social compact with broad support to guide the country forward and inform future National Development Plan.

Hon House Chair, the budget provides for strengthening Nedlac's capacity to fulfil this mandate effectively. Targeted capacity building for social partners ensures that all voices, especially of labour and community formations that are historically marginalised, are heard and meaningfully participate in policy discourse. Nedlac's role integrating climate change and just transition policies within its dialogue framework, in collaboration with the Presidential Climate Commission, is a forward-looking alignment with global

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imperatives that safeguard sustainable development and decent work.

Effective governance and budget-oversighted Nedlac guarantees that this inclusive dialogue translates not only into discussion but into actionable socioeconomic policies that drive growth, create jobs and reduce poverty, in line with our Manifesto of 2024, where, in fact, we put forward in terms of Priority 2, that is, build our industries for an inclusive economy by implementing a cross-cutting industrial strategy that drives growth and creates opportunities for youth and other unemployed persons. Nedlac's work promotes social cohesion by building trust amongst partners and mitigating labour market conflicts before they escalate, fostering a stable environment conducive to investment and employment.

Hon House Chair, the Department of Employment and Labour, supported by this budget, is poised to launch a direct and multidimensional fight against the skyrocketing unemployment crisis that afflict our people. This crisis demands interventions that are strategic, institutionally supported, and socially inclusive. In strengthening the CCMA, we are fortifying labour market stability by ensuring that workplace



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disputes are resolved efficiently, allowing businesses to operate uninterrupted workers to secure their livelihoods. Empowering Nedlac, we need to deepen social dialogue that informs policy imperative that is reflective of shared national interests, fostering consensus that balances economic growth with worker protections.

Addressing legacy institutional challenges within these bodies remain critical. We must modernise, professionalise, and streamline processes that meet the demands of the often dynamic and often voluntary labour market. This budget is therefore a critical enabler to both transformation within this institution, ensuring that they better serve the workers, employers and the communities they represent.

Hon House Chair, unemployment in South Africa is not merely a statistic. It is a human tragedy and an economic barrier. It undermines social cohesion and threatens the gains of our democratic order. Our commitment through this budget is to empower institutions that can deliver tangible results, such as reduction in labour market conflicts, creation of sustainable jobs, improved worker protection and inclusive social partnership. It is an ANC policy imperative to build an

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economy that works for all South Africans by fostering a labour market that is fair and conducive to inclusive growth. I therefore urge this Assembly to support the proposed budget as an investment in the country's future, in the dignity of work, and in the social dialogue mechanisms that underpin a stable and prosperous South Africa.

Together, through CCMA and Nedlac, through firm government leadership and collaborative partnership that the hon Minister has spoken above, enable supported by both Deputy Minister and hon Chairperson of the committee, we shall overcome the challenge of unemployment and build a society reflective of our shared aspiration for freedom, justice and economic emancipation.

Hon Chair, just in conclusion, there is a just, a free reference regarding the work that has been done to deal with corruption. It's just freely available information if you can just Google it, hon members. It says high profile and recent cases. In Mpumalanga, the ghost worker scheme, three suspects were arrested for allegedly claiming R27 million from Unemployment Insurance Fund, UIF, using 700 fictitious employees. I go further, KwaZulu-Natal syndicate. On December

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2025, the Special Investigating Unit, SIU, alongside police ... It's freely available. You don't have to ... It's freely available. [Time expired.]

The MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR: Hon Mbele from the MK, please, we are busy cleaning the mess that your President, Mr Gedleyihlekisa Zuma created in the country for 10 years now. We are busy fixing Transnet, Eskom. We are busy fighting the corruption that he made so institutional in our country.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Minister, will you take a seat with points of order.

Ms N BUTHELEZI: Chair, the Minister is out of order. Jacob Zuma is not with us in this House. Therefore, she must not come here and call his name on whatever they were doing. Hon Minister, stay out of President Zuma's name. That is out of order, Chairperson.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon members, if you continue like this, I will put off all the microphones. We cannot continue like this. Every one of you who wants to shout at another person, can you please leave the Chamber and take

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your fight outside? If you want to raise a point of order based on the procedures and order content of the debate, then you can raise your point of order.

I've already made a rule on the referral to the EFF's president. I'm not going to take any more points of order. Hon Minister, please continue.

The MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR: You come here and shout the loudest about corruption you cannot prove. Yet, your party is born out of the most corrupt individuals in the country.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Minister, will you please take your seat? There's a point of order. Hon member, can you please raise your point of order?

Mr S I GAMA: House Chair, I would like the Minister to withdraw the reference to former President Zuma in terms of what she is alleging, because President Zuma is not in this House. There's no need for her to name someone who is not in this House. She has called him by name.

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The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Thank you, hon member. Because of the shouting, I couldn't hear clearly what she said. I will refer to the Hansard and make a ruling. Thank you. Minister, will you continue?

The MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR: Hon Mokwele, you disappoint me. You are the member of the portfolio committee and as the Ministry and the Department, we report to the portfolio committee all the time. You know that there is a system called ESA, which is the largest job seeker database or system in the country. Please, go report to your CIC, who said if the Department of Employment was effective, it would have that system. The system is there.

Ms T J MOKWELE: On a point of order, Chair.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Mokwele, what is your point of order?

Ms T J MOKWELE: My surname is not Mokwela, it's Mokwele.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Mokwele.

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Ms T J MOKWELE: Mokwele, yes. I'm raising a concern again, Chair. You ruled on it, but it resurfaced again. The Minister says I must go and report to the CIC. She must report to the unemployed youth who are sitting there - unemployed.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Mokwele!

Ms T J MOKWELE: She must leave our CIC. The CIC is not in this House. The CIC is not in this House with due respect, hon Chair. He's not in this House. The Minister must respond to the issues that affect people of South Africa ...

[Interjections.].

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Mokwele, you are now making a speech. That is not a point of order, anymore. Hon Mokwele, please take your seat. Hon Minister, please continue.

The MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR: So, the hon members who are here deployed by different organisation must also empower their organisations. That there is a system in South Africa which has more than 8 million people who are in the database with almost 4 million young people.

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Ms T J MOKWELE: It's not working.

The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon Mokwele! Hon Minister, please take your seat. Hon Mokwele, I am naming you. Please, respect the order of this House. Hon Minister, please continue.

The MINISTER OF EMPLOYMENT AND LABOUR: I call upon all the employers to consult that system. It's got details of CVs of South Africans, including the young people who are close to 4 million, with a detail that says: What skill do you have? Where do you stay? So, the issue of pressing a button and going ... and get a chef is in that system.

I want to also say to the employers, they must stop the mischief of sidelining young South Africans and South Africans in general, because they want to use the foreign nationals for cheap labour. They want to also exploit them and avoid compliance with the laws of this country. We are coming for you, because we are dealing with those who are employing illegal workers. We process them. But we are coming even for those who are employing those who are legal in South Africa without having a scarce skill that we must be importing as the

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country. That's why we have the National Labour Migration Policy, NLMP, that we have passed.

We are bringing to Parliament the Employment Service Amendment Bill, ESAB, that will give the Minister powers to ensure that quotas and sectors are set aside only for South Africans in terms of the low skills. I'm expecting the EFF members, when we come to Parliament with that ESA Bill, that they will support it.

I want to also say to the members who are here, they must go and read the speech, because unfortunately I only presented the abridged speech. We are starting to implement our mandate, our role as public employment programmes co-ordinator. Hence, you are saying in the speech, there is a framework that you conducted a study working with all the serious institutions of this country, including Nelson Mandela University. That study is saying there's 106 public employment programmes that are causing duplication, fragmentation, and we are bringing a framework so that we can coordinate the work that is done by public employment programmes. That is doing our work as the Department of Employment and Labour.



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Hon Bagraim, I sometimes get worried, because you've got a law. You are a law student and as such, you should understand that the employment mandate that was given to the Department of Employment and Labour does not necessarily mean it must employ people. You mischievously also admit that there is stability. There are green shoots, and you choose to claim them to be GNU green shoots. So, you know that the economy is stabilising. Yes, we agree.

We have not yet realised the number of absorptions of those who are the labour force by the labour market as we would have loved. That's why we are bringing here programmes to intervene. That's why we have budgeted R36,6 billion for the Labour Activation Programme.

Hon Mokwele, there are inspectors. There is a budget. I told you it's R5 billion that we've budgeted, and 10,000 have already been recruited and successfully uploaded into the system. Thank you very much, Chair

Ms T J MOKWELE: Where is the recruiting? Where?

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The CHAIRPERSON (Ms C Labuschagne): Hon members, that concludes the debate and the business of this mini-plenary session.

Debate concluded.

The mini plenary session rose at 18:43.